Offline: The past is not the future

Cesar Victora delivered a terrific Pumphandle Lecture at the London School of Hygiene & Tropical Medicine last week. He surveyed 40 years of his research on child health and nutrition in Pelotas, Brazil. His message to an audience of mostly young students was simple but immensely powerful—you can remain in your home country and do research that makes a difference. His career amply proved his proposition, from work on exclusive breastfeeding under a military dictatorship to the design of WHO child growth standards, from his team's construction of an ambitious series of birth cohorts to his work on global equity monitoring. His life lesson was this: living in a place helps one to have good ideas. "Move to the South", he urged. At a time when faith in a global health system forged over the past quarter century is under severe strain, Cesar's words were more than a balm—they were an inspiration. But the past is no guide to the future. The progress that Victora described, which contributed to halving under-5 child mortality over two decades, is extremely fragile. Reversals are possible. So how might the future unfold? And what should we do about the futures we identify?

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In *If Russia Wins: A Scenario* (2025), Carlo Masala imagines a Russian attack on Estonia and the consequences of that attack over the next three days. The background is one we will readily recognise—NATO's failure to engage Russia in the defence of Ukraine, our blindness to Vladimir Putin's goal of bringing all Russian-speaking peoples within his sphere of control, and the present unreliability of the US as a defender of European security. What Masala urges is "thinking through scenarios" to simulate potential futures. He writes that, "Scenarios expand the realm of possibilities in our minds. They serve to counteract intellectual complacency and short-term political horizons. What is at stake…only really sinks in when we think about what could happen if things do not turn out well." As a past Deputy Director in the research department at the NATO Defence College in Rome, he bases his scenario on evidence accumulated from his own experiences and discussions with security experts. Masala demands realism in our foreign policy: "Russia poses the greatest security threat for the European continent in the foreseeable future." His criticism is that "there has never been a clear strategy among Western leaders" about how to deal with Russia. He accuses Western powers of ignoring the truth that Putin is nothing less than a dictator. "It is therefore not unrealistic", he concludes, "that Russia would put NATO to the test." He calls on Western governments to communicate exactly what is at risk.

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How might we apply scenarios to health and provoke more engaged attention from political leaders and the public? COVID-19 was a lesson in failure. The scenarios governments and health agencies modelled were too narrowly focused on influenza. Coronaviruses were omitted from rational speculation, at the cost of millions of lives. Alarmingly, we continue to make those same mistakes today. Health leaders are insufficiently open-minded about the threats around us. Where are the scenarios, for example, modelling a pandemic of Nipah virus? Where is the effort to communicate now about those threats rather than wait until it is too late? What is the plan for building public trust in advance of the next pandemic? There are hopeful signs that scenarios are being introduced into health policy planning. *The Lancet*'s Series on Alzheimer's disease examined three approaches to planning for increased numbers of patients living with dementia—disease centred, patient centred, and population centred. The actions that follow from each approach—eg, with respect to access to anti-amyloid monoclonal antibodies—differ radically. In the EAT–*Lancet* Commission on healthy, sustainable, and just food systems, three core scenarios were considered—business-as-usual, middle-of-the-road, and transformational. Only the transformational scenario provided a safe solution to the twin crises of climate change and biodiversity loss. Cesar Victora's lessons from the past offer invaluable instruction about how to make research count under less than favourable material circumstances. But we should recognise the danger of contingency. The future should be its own independent variable in our modelling and planning. We should take those futures much more seriously. The future is, after all, the arena in which justice for health will be won or lost.

Richard Horton
richard.horton@lancet.com

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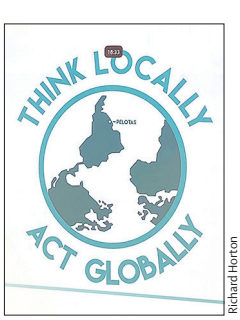

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